

Weekly Presentation

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Readings

- Drucker 2021, Ch.2: modeling, tokenization, parameterization, cleaning, ethics
- Gitelman 2013: no “raw” data, be transparent
- **Havens et al. 2024, MELP: crowdsourcing, TEI, IDs, authority links (Team 2)**

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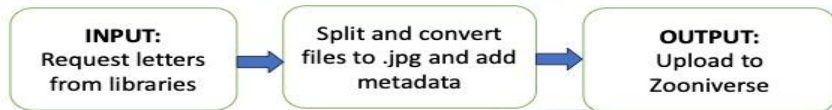
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Short Summary

The Maria Edgeworth Letters Project (MELP)

- transform Maria Edgeworth's physical letters into a searchable, digital database.
- **"as-is" approach**: preserving the original form of the letters
- operates in three main stages: archiving, transcription, and encoding
- use TEI schema and XML format, and using **Zooniverse** platform to invite volunteers into transcription stage

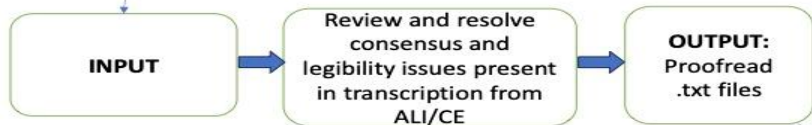
PRE-TRANSCRIPTION PROCESSING



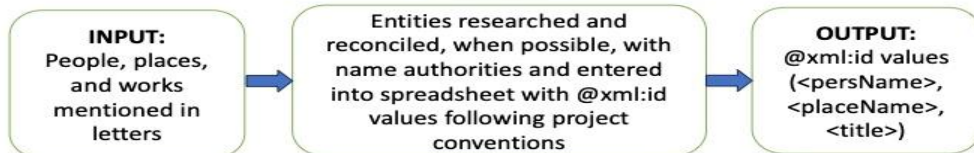
TRANSCRIPTION



TRANSCRIPTION REVIEW



DEFINE "OGRAPHY" ENTITIES



ENCODING



Short Summary

transcription



encoding

- volunteers transcribe letters
- researchers choose the **most statistically** common choice
- "the wisdom of crowds"
- created "**ography**" files that are linked to external, open databases
- apply the **TEI tags** to the letter text using the "ography" file information



MARIA EDGEWORTH LETTERS PROJECT

The Maria Edgeworth Letters Project is a collaborative digital edition of letters written by Maria Edgeworth and shared by over 30 archives around the world. We are currently in the process of transcribing these letters through the Zooniverse crowdsourcing platform with the goal of creating a fully searchable database of her letters.

General editors of the project are Susan Egenolf, Meredith Hale, Hilary Havens, Jessica Richard, and Robin Runia.
The digital team is Carrie Johnston and Bryan Tarpley.
Design by Kayley Hart and KWALL.

[ABOUT THE PROJECT](#)

Not just creating a digital archive, they are trying to establish a new model for **ethical, open, and highly collaborative** digital humanities research.

The relevance between this week's topic and this article

Data creation

unstructured handwritten letters
-> structured digital data

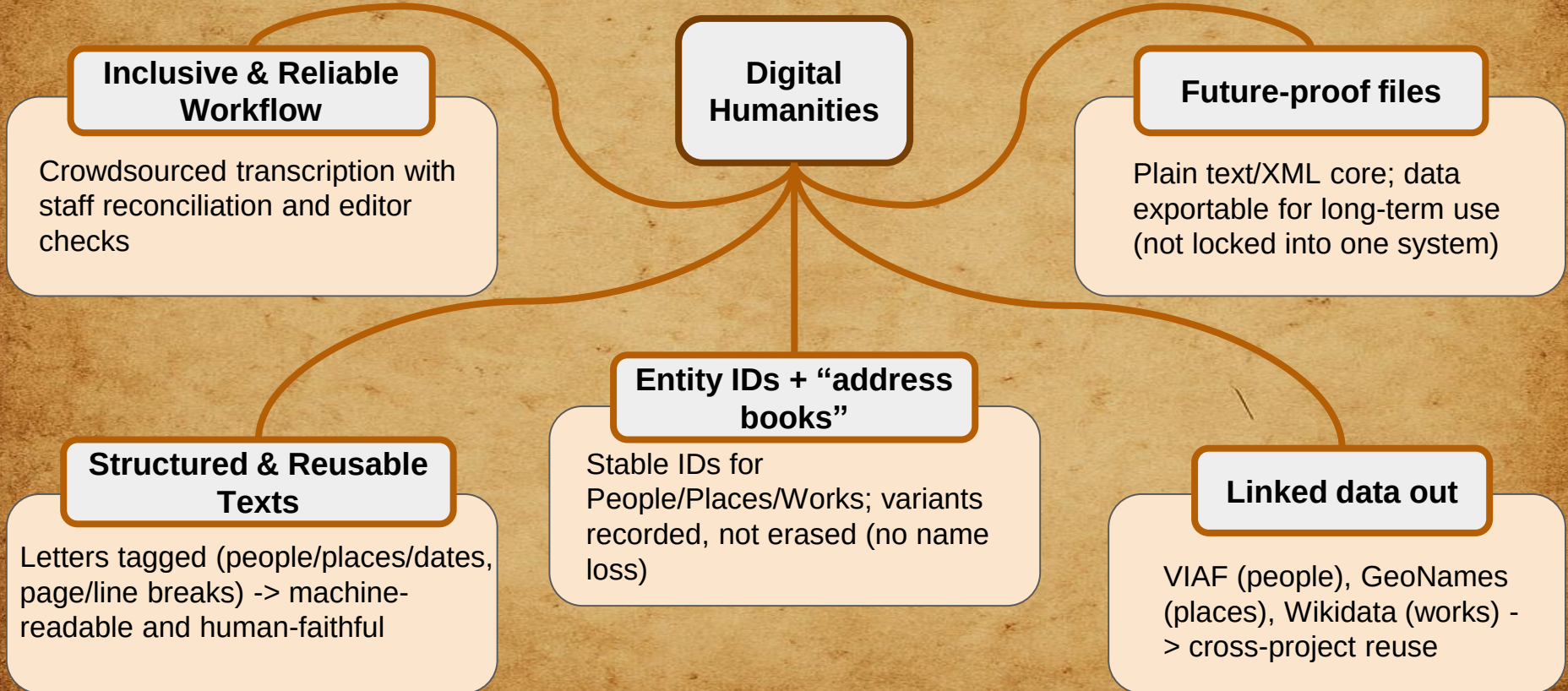
Data Curation

- create tutorial
- select the most statistically common choice
- upload the result online

Digital Archives

- use digital tools
- link to external and open databases
- align with other institution in coding in some way (ex.delete "gender")

What MELP contributes to Digital Humanities (DH)



What the other readings contribute

“Raw Data” Is an Oxymoron (Gitelman)

Thesis: Data is made through choices and contexts (no “raw” data)

Impact: forces transparency of selection, modeling and “cleaning”; critiques myths of objectivity

The DH Coursebook, Ch 2 (Drucker)

Field manual: How to model humanities data

Methods: Tokenization, parameterization, cleaning docs

Standards: Unique IDs, vocabularies, data formats, ethics & privacy checklists

Topics of concern

Ethics & Privacy

Labor & Credit

Standards vs specificity

Sustainability

Available solutions

Consent, provenance,
careful reuse

Acknowledge authors

Shared IDs without
cultural erasure

Durable formats,
maintenance plans



Critique & Practical Mitigations

Strengths:

- Transparent pipeline
- Durable core
- Linked-data friendly

Risks:

- Varying speed/accuracy
- Tagging needs training
- Funding-dependent
- Maintenance-dependent

Critique & Practical Mitigations

Method fit:

- Natural match with letters
- Scalable crowdsourcing
- Evolvable schema and spellings

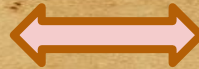
Mitigations:

- Hand-written text recognition
- Templates + short trainings
- Recurring maintenance
- Automated checks

Comparison of the Readings

Comparing the readings

- Drucker (2021) provides practical questions
- Compare data models from MELP and the VOC-Opvarenden enhancement project



Similarities & Differences

- Digitizing historical artifacts:
 - → Edgeworth: 1768-1859,
 - → muster records: 1633-1794
- Struggles in completeness:
 - → MELP > VOC
- Transparency:
 - → MELP > VOC

Reflection of the implications

Implications for future research

- MELP and its humanistic approach to outsourced labor
- Developing countries & ethically questionable working conditions
- Gamechanger for modern day research methods?
- Drucker's checklists for personal use

New understandings of the VOC-Opvarenden project

- The completeness of MELP in the three components of digital humanities
→ (materials, processing and presentation)
- More insight in limitations VOC:
 - Type II errors
- More attention needed for the VOC as a black page in history

MELP

"Is the essay on the MELP project too good to be true?"

(Un)Structured

In Drucker's terms, what did MELP actually structure and what did they leave unstructured on purpose? Does that feel like the right mix?

Clean vs Messy

Where do you draw the line between cleaning and keeping the mess (weird spellings, cross-outs)? Pick one: names / dates / places.

History

How is the VOC's violent past considered to keep the project fair and balanced?

Sustainability

If funding stopped next year, which three things do we have to keep so the dataset still works, TEI/XML export, data dictionary, cleaning log, DOIs, code, or something else?

Tokenization

If 'Washington' might be a person or a place, how would you tag it in MELP when you're unsure?

Questions

References

- Drucker, Johanna. *The Digital Humanities Coursebook: An Introduction to Digital Methods for Research and Scholarship*. Routledge, 2021. <https://vu.on.worldcat.org/oclc/1236262568>
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- Havens, Hilary, Eliza Alexander Wilcox, Meredith L. Hale, and Jamie Kramer. 'From Archive to Database: Using Crowdsourcing, TEI, and Collaborative Labor to Construct the Maria Edgeworth Letters Project'. *Digital Humanities Quarterly* 18, no. 2 (2024). <https://digitalhumanities.org/dhq/vol/18/2/000424/000424.html>
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